

The Questions of Vimaladatta

Āryavimaladattatāparipṛcchā nāma mahāyānasūtra · Toh 77 · Derge Kangyur

འཕགས་པ་དཀྱིལ་མདོ་གསུ་བརྒྱ་པས་ཞུ་བ།

The Questions of Vimaladatta, known in Sanskrit as the Āryavimaladattatāparipṛcchā and in Tibetan as Drimé Kyijinpé Zhüpa, is a Mahāyāna sūtra presented as a discourse given by the Buddha in the Jeta Grove at Śrāvastī before a great assembly of monks. The text belongs to the genre of "questions" sūtras, in which a named figure poses inquiries that occasion the Buddha's teaching, and it concerns the dharma as transmitted through the interlocutor Vimaladatta. It is Toh 77 in the Kangyur, where it appears not as a standalone work but as Chapter Thirty-Three of the vast compendium known as the Great Jewel Heap, the Ratnakūṭa collection, which gathers one hundred thousand chapters of dharma synonyms under a single canonical heading.

The Noble Great Jewel Heap: The Dharma Synonyms in One Hundred Thousand Chapters, Chapter Thirty-Three: The Prophecy Requested by Noble Vimaladatta. First Section.

In the language of India: Āryavimaladattatāparipṛcchā nāma mahāyānasūtra.

In the Tibetan language: The Noble Great Vehicle Sūtra Called "The Questions of Vimaladatta."

Homage to all buddhas and bodhisattvas.

Thus did I hear. At one time the Blessed One was dwelling in Śrāvastī, in the Jeta Grove, the garden of Anāthapiṇḍada, together with a great Saṅgha of twelve hundred and fifty monks. All of them were arhats: their defilements exhausted, their afflictions extinguished, endowed with mastery, utterly and perfectly liberated in mind, utterly and perfectly liberated in wisdom, knowing all that was to be known, great elephants, who had done what was to be done and accomplished what was to be accomplished, who had laid down their burden, attained their own good, utterly worn away all bonds to existence, and perfectly liberated in mind through perfect knowledge. They had reached the very summit of perfect mastery over every power of mind — all of them, with a single exception, namely the venerable Ānanda.

Also present were some ten thousand bodhisattvas, almost all of them irreversible, bound by just one more birth, namely: the bodhisattva Ratnāloka, the bodhisattva Prajñārāśī, the bodhisattva Śrīgarbha, the bodhisattva

Yaśomati, Pratibhānarāśi, Avalokiteśvara, Mahāsthāmaprāpta, Maitreya, Aśokadatta, the youthful Mañjuśrī, Vikrāntacārin Amogha, Darśanāmogha, Durgatīśodhana, the Destroyer of All Darkness of Grief, he who is ever adorned with flowers of precious qualities, he of the splendor of golden-garland radiance, Sarvāvaraṇaviśkambhin, and the bodhisattva Asaṅgamati — along with these and still other bodhisattvas, ten thousand in all, gathered together.

Then the venerable Śāriputra, the venerable Mahāmaudgalyāyana, the venerable Pūrṇamaitrāyaṇīputra, the venerable Mahākāśyapa, the venerable Subhūti, the venerable Nandika, the venerable Aniruddha, and the venerable Ānanda — those eight great hearers — together with the bodhisattva Mañjuśrī, the bodhisattva Durgatīśodhana, Ratnaketu, Darśanāmogha, Sarvāvaraṇaviśkambhin, the noble Avalokiteśvara, Pratibhānarāśi, and the bodhisattva Vikrāntacārin Amogha — those eight great bodhisattvas — in the morning hour put on their lower robes and outer Dharma garments, took up their alms bowls, and entered the great city of Śrāvastī for alms. While they were still along the way, they spoke these words: "Whoever can enter the city should first enter meditative absorption of such a kind that all assemblies of people in the city will hear the discourse of the noble truths."

The venerable Śāriputra then said: I shall enter meditative absorption of such a kind that the wisdom of all assemblies of people in the city with respect to the noble truths will be unobstructed, and all darkness and deep darkness will be absent from their wisdom — and having entered such absorption, I shall go into the city.

The venerable Mahāmaudgalyāyana then spoke:

I shall enter meditative absorption of such a kind that, by it, no works of Māra will arise for any of the assemblies of people in the city — and having entered such absorption, I shall go into the city.

The venerable Mahāmaudgalyāyana then spoke: I shall enter meditative absorption of such a kind that all the other tīrthikas — the wanderers, the naked ascetics, the livelihood-seekers, the brahmins, and the householders who are dwelling in the city — will not come to hold wrong views — and having entered such absorption, I shall go into the city.

The venerable Mahākāśyapa then spoke: I shall enter meditative absorption of such a kind that all the men, women, boys, and girls dwelling in the city who give us alms will all attain inexhaustible enjoyment of resources until they reach nirvāṇa — and having entered such absorption, I shall go into the city.

The venerable Subhūti then spoke: I shall enter meditative absorption of such a kind that all the assemblies of people in the city will attain freedom from affliction — and having entered such absorption, I shall go into the city.

The venerable Nāgasena then spoke: I shall enter meditative absorption of such a kind that all the assemblies of people in the city will attain meditative absorption — and having entered such absorption, I shall go into the city.

The venerable Aniruddha then spoke: I shall enter meditative absorption of such a kind that all the assemblies of people in the city will attain the happiness of freedom from illness — and having entered such absorption, I shall go into the city.

The venerable Ānanda then spoke: I shall enter meditative absorption of such a kind that Dharma teachings never before heard will become manifest to all the assemblies of people in the city — and having entered such absorption, I shall go into the city.

Mañjuśrī, the youthful prince of Dharma, then spoke: I shall hold in mind the intention that from the doors, windows, walls, vessels, ornaments, trees, leaves, flowers, fruits, and garments in the city there will arise the sound of emptiness, the sound of signlessness, the sound of wishlessness, the sound of non-arising, the sound of non-existence, and the sound of selflessness.

The bodhisattva Remover of Evil Rebirths then spoke: Whatever there may be that would cause sentient beings in the city to experience evil rebirths — I shall hold in mind the intention that they will experience only a slight ripening of that in this very life itself.

The bodhisattva Meaningful Sight then spoke: I shall hold in mind the intention that all sentient beings in the city who come into the range of my gaze will see the form of a Tathāgata.

The bodhisattva Jewel Crest then spoke: I shall hold in mind the intention that in every home in the city there will arise treasures filled to overflowing with precious gems.

The bodhisattva Dispeller of All Obscurations then spoke: I shall hold in mind the intention that the five obscurations of all the assemblies of people in the great city of Śrāvastī will be completely cleared away.

The bodhisattva Avalokiteśvara then spoke: I shall hold in mind the intention that whatever sentient beings in the city are bound —

— those who are being led away to be killed will all be freed, and those threatened by fear will attain freedom from harm. Such is the intention I shall hold in mind.

The bodhisattva Stacked Eloquence then spoke: I shall hold in mind the intention that all assemblies of people in the city will speak to one another in melodious verse and with a mind of loving-kindness, and will also attain eloquence. Such is the intention I shall hold in mind.

The bodhisattva Meaningful Stride then spoke: I shall hold in mind the intention that whatever sentient beings in the city come within range of my sight will all become irreversible in their progress toward unsurpassed, perfect, and complete awakening. Such is the intention I shall hold in mind.

Then those great śrāvakas and those bodhisattvas, speaking such words as these among themselves, went on toward the great city of Śrāvastī.

Now at that very time there was a daughter of Prasenajit, king of the land of Kośala, named Vimaladattā — Spotlessly Given. She had previously served the Victors with great devotion, had cultivated roots of virtue, had paid reverence to many buddhas, was endowed with patient acceptance of the profound Dharma, and had attained the five superknowledges. With a divine eye of perfect purity surpassing human capacity, this maiden saw those bodhisattvas and those great śrāvakas and heard every word they spoke to one another along the way.

This maiden was beautiful and lovely to behold, endowed with a splendid and radiant complexion of the highest excellence, beloved of her parents and household. She had been born twelve years before. On that day — the eighth day of the last month of spring, under the constellation Uttarāṣāḍhā — her parents, desiring auspicious signs and good omens for her, had dispatched five hundred brahmins carrying curds, kuśa grass, flowers, kindling wood, butter, and water-vessels, and were leading her to a bathing rite. It was these brahmins who caught sight of those bodhisattvas and those great śrāvakas. And having seen them, they remained with the perception that this was an inauspicious omen.

Then from among those brahmins, the eldest, named Brahmadeva, spoke thus to the maiden Vimaladattā: "Maiden, these monks standing before us are inauspicious. If one sees them, whatever one desires — wealth, vows, sacrifice, or good fortune — none of it will be accomplished. Let us turn back into the city."

Thereupon the maiden Vimaladattā addressed the brahmin Brahmadeva in verse:

These ones are of supreme virtue, free from attachment and altogether wholesome;

they destroy the wrongdoing of the multitude of beings.

These ones are utterly pure, and they see the Four Truths;

they are disciplined, liberated, and abide in meditative equipoise.

These ones are the supreme merit-field of two-legged beings;

one who offers a gift to them proceeds to the high realms.

One who offers a gift to them attains the deathless fruit;

having given, one will not go to lower states of existence.

They are endowed with moral discipline and with restraint;

they have transcended desire and are without wrongdoing, free of craving.

These are the supreme physicians who move through the world;

they liberate living beings tormented by suffering.

In the world the Buddha is the lord of Dharma;

these, his sons, are without dust, without affliction.

Among these there are also many other bodhisattvas —

how could a person of wisdom ever shun them?

These ones practice austere observances and have stilled attachment;

they are auspicious, and the wise pour down a rain of giving.

Even if one shows them little respect,

still people will succeed in Dharma and likewise in wealth.

These ones possess all major marks and are endowed with auspiciousness;

they are endowed with a supremely pure mind, a field of the highest excellence.

Brahmin, who is it that would have faith in this?

That will generate abundant merit.

Then the brahmin god Brahmadeva spoke in verse once more in response to the gift given by the maiden Vimaladattā:

Do not let yourself be ruled by a childish mind.

Look now, at this time of the sacrifice, at the nuns —

those who wear ocher robes and have likewise shaved their heads:

do not look upon them thinking they will serve your purpose.

Your father and mother will not be pleased,
and I myself will be condemned by the wise.
Your sacrifice will not succeed.
Therefore, shun the monks and nuns utterly.

Then Vimaladattā spoke in verse back to the brahmin god Brahmadeva in response to his gift:

Apart from these ones who are endowed with virtue,
neither father nor mother is my refuge.
Neither kinfolk, nor wealth, nor youth —
these ones are the refuge of those who have sunk in saṃsāra.
I have gladly given up my body for the sake of the buddhas,
and likewise given up my life and my possessions.
Save for the Three Jewels themselves being my refuge,
there is, for me, no sentient being in this world upon whom I take refuge.

Then the brahmin god Brahmadeva spoke to the maiden Vimaladattā as follows: "Daughter, since your birth you have never before seen a buddha, never before heard the Dharma, never before paid reverence to the Saṅgha — why then have you come to have faith in the Buddha?"

Vimaladattā replied: "Brahmin, seven days after my birth, when I had been placed upon a golden throne inside a sandalwood palace, I saw five hundred sons of the gods (devaputras) moving through the sky above, and I heard them praising the Buddha in many ways, praising the Dharma and praising the Saṅgha.

Then, from among those sons of the gods, the one who had previously seen the Tathāgata was questioned by the others: 'Friend, what is the Tathāgata like? How is one to know him?' That son of the gods, understanding my thought, then spoke these verses in order to inspire faith in those other sons of the gods as well:

His hair is immaculate, glossy, and beautiful,
with a lock that swirls to the right, clean and soft.
His face is like the full-open petals of a lotus,
lovely as the full moon glowing in the night sky.
His ūrṇā hair is of the color of fine white crystal,
curling between the brows, supremely beautiful.

He sits, outshining his entire retinue,
making the Victor's face yet more magnificent to behold.

The Lord of Men's eyes are beautiful; his cheeks are like a lion's.
His mind is vigorous and unshrinking; his teeth are even and his jaws are fine.
His great tongue covers the full circle of his mouth.
His face is immaculate and supremely beautiful.

His speech is beneficial, pleasing, and fitting.
Abandoning harsh words, he does not reveal wrongdoing; he is without fault.
He consorts with countless beings
and proclaims the Victor's word for the welfare of all those who wander.

His neck is like a conch shell, equal and perfect.
Likewise, the Lord of Men's fingers are long.
His hands are like the trunk of a great elephant.
His chest is broad and immaculate; his navel is deep and recessed.
Like a supreme horse, the hair of his body is concealed within the skin.
Likewise, his pores are like gold.
The shape of his thighs is like an elephant's trunk.
His feet are well-planted and auspicious, like those of an eina deer.

The Sovereign of Sages is free from the fault of arrogance in his true words.
He destroys the sinful views of those who cling to bad omens.
Though questioned by tens of millions in his assembly,
he is without error and free from fault, satisfying every sentient being.

Without deceit, he satisfies beings with honest speech.
Nirvāṇa — supreme bliss, joy, true peace —
he reveals the joy of nirvāṇa pleasing to every person,
and he also teaches the Middle Way free from both extremes.

He himself became a buddha,
crossed over himself, and liberates others too.
He is the protector and refuge of all beings, their auspicious good,
and for the whole world he acts with loving care and benefit.

These qualities of the Teacher, and yet others
beyond all limit, I have not declared.
Having heard this, the gods were filled with joy and faith,
and they cultivate a mind of devotion toward the Victor.

Then the girl Vimaladatta spoke these verses and addressed the brahmin Brahmadeva saying: "Brahmin, I was born seven days ago, and yet I have heard qualities of the buddha such as these. I remember them fully, and from that time forward I have never been overcome by dullness or sleep. Never did I entertain thoughts of desire — the conceptuality that conceptualizes desire — nor thoughts of ill-will — the conceptuality that conceptualizes ill-will — nor thoughts of harmfulness — the conceptuality that conceptualizes harmfulness. I remember that from that time forward I never gave rise to delight in a father, delight in a mother, delight in a brother, delight in a sister, delight in a kinsman, delight in wealth, delight in ornaments, delight in clothes, delight in the body, delight in life, delight in a town, or delight in sense bases. Brahmin, in all other respects, I remember only the buddha himself.

Brahmin, with three things held in my mind, I have kept them well in mind: in which direction the Tathāgata resides, all the Dharma the Tathāgata has taught — all of it I have grasped well, not letting a single word or syllable go to waste. And I have never failed to keep in mind the Tathāgata surrounded by his Saṅgha of monks. Not for a single day or night has it come to pass that I did not see the buddha, did not hear the Dharma, or did not pay homage to the Saṅgha. Brahmin, for me there is no satiation in beholding the buddha, in hearing the Dharma, or in paying homage to the Saṅgha."

Then the brahmin Brahmadeva said to a young brahmin student: "Young brahmin, go and report this account to the king and queen." That young brahmin student then departed swiftly and reported to the king and queen everything he had seen.

Vimaladatta too, just as the brahmin Brahmadeva and the five hundred brahmin scholars had aroused the mind of unsurpassable, perfect, complete awakening — she likewise proclaimed the praises of the buddha, proclaimed the praises of the Dharma, and proclaimed the praises of the Saṅgha.

Then Vimaladatta descended from her chariot, and together with those brahmin scholars she went to where those bodhisattvas and those great śrāvakas were. Arriving there, she prostrated with her head at their feet, and then with reverence and due respect she sat down before the Venerable Śāriputra, turned with joined palms toward where the Venerable Śāriputra was, and spoke to the Venerable Śāriputra these words:

"Venerable Śāriputra, women have only half the wisdom of men; their afflictions are intense; they are greatly heedless; they are given to the inferior;

and they are subject to a mind that does not attend to things as they are. Therefore I ask that, taking compassion on me, you please teach me the Dharma well, so that I may have long-term benefit, healing, and happiness."

When Prasenajit, king of Kosala, heard this account and these words of the brahmin, he went swiftly to that place, paid homage to those śrāvakas and those bodhisattvas, and then said to his own daughter: "My daughter, is it true that you have never been overcome by dullness or sleep?"

"I say that I have never given rise to a mind associated with delight and play." So it is — do you truly strive after physical ease and mental comfort? Or else do you speak in this way merely as a matter of proper conduct, moved by a sense of weariness with the world?

Then King Prasenajit (the king of Kosala) addressed his daughter in verse:

Your form, pure as a divine maiden's, is without equal and unmatched,
adorned with ornaments, you bear the beauty of one fully decked in finery.
How is it that you have never been overcome by sleep?
Why, my daughter, have you come to a mind so wearied of this?
Your royal domain flourishes and is exceedingly well provided.
Your mother is ever wholly under your sway.
My daughter, if there is any other joy like that,
has your body not found delight in it?
You are lovely and tender and pleasing to behold,
the cause of joy to every person you meet.
Adorned with hundreds upon hundreds of virtues,
why is it that you find no joy in this house?
My daughter, what have you heard,
what have you seen, that you are so ill at ease,
so utterly exhausted and wearied at heart?
Tell me — what is it that you desire?

Then the daughter, Vimaladattā, addressed her father King Prasenajit in verse:

Dear father, have you not taken to heart
the faults and failings of the aggregates, those vessels of defect,
and the flaws of household life?
A place in saṃsāra is like a theatrical spectacle —
the world in which we live does not abide; it is subject to destruction.
In a house where venomous serpents dwell within,
where can there be sleep or the pursuit of desire?

These four elements (mahābhūtas) are four deadly serpents —
where can there be ease or peace of mind in this existence?
Harassed on all sides by unkind companions,
where can there be joy if one goes to a solitary place?
Surrounded on every side by the enemy of afflictions,
how can one find happiness? Pray tell me, O King.
Where is there happiness for one who has drunk poison?
Where is there joy for one being led to slaughter?
Who would place their trust in this great abyss?
O King, that is what the world in which we live resembles.
Those of foolish mind who abandon their bodies —
the Tathāgata has taught the example, saying:
"The heap of bodies cast off amounts to a mass as great as Mount Meru."
Who then would trust in conditioned phenomena, those Dharmas of deceitful
falsity?
Father, mother, beloved, brother,
children, grandchildren, all one's kinsmen, all beings —
all conditioned things are like reflections in a mirror.
Who would place their trust in anything so unlovely as this?
When I behold the self-arisen Victor,
the thought arises in me: "May I too become a buddha."
As for a bodhisattva becoming heedless,
dear father, I have never heard of such a thing, never seen it.
I wish to gaze upon the Victor complete in all his marks,
to hear the Dharma proclaimed by the Sugata (the Well-Gone, the Buddha),
and to behold the Victor and the Victor's sons.
Dear father, how can I pursue pleasures and desires?
Then King Prasenajit, having heard these words of his daughter, fell utterly
silent.

Then the daughter Vimaladattā, knowing that her father had fallen silent,
addressed the venerable Śāriputra with these words: "Venerable Śāriputra, I
make a request of you — please, in your compassion, be so good as to
respond. The venerable Śāriputra has been shown by the Blessed One to be
foremost among those endowed with wisdom. Now I ask: is that wisdom
conditioned or unconditioned? If it is conditioned, then the Tathāgata has
declared that all conditioned things are false, possessed of the character of

deception. But if it is unconditioned, then in the unconditioned there is no arising. And where there is no arising, there is no encounter. If it is a wisdom with which there is no encounter, how can you, venerable Śāriputra, be called 'one of great wisdom'?"

Then the venerable Śāriputra fell utterly silent.

Then the venerable Mahāmaudgalyāyana spoke to the venerable Śāriputra and said: "Śāriputra, answer the girl's question." Śāriputra replied: "The girl is not asking about the conditioned. She has asked about the unborn, and I am unable to answer that."

Then the girl Vimaladattā spoke to the venerable Mahāmaudgalyāyana and said: "Thus, venerable Mahāmaudgalyāyana, you have been shown by the Blessed One to be foremost among those endowed with miraculous powers. Now I ask: does the venerable one display miraculous powers while abiding in the perception of sentient beings, or while abiding in the perception of phenomena? If he displays them while abiding in the perception of sentient beings, then sentient beings have no real existence, and thus those miraculous powers would likewise have no real existence. But if he displays them while abiding in the perception of phenomena, then the nature of phenomena is without change. And in that which is without change there is no conceptual thought. If there is no conceptual thought, how did the venerable one come to possess miraculous powers?" The venerable Mahāmaudgalyāyana fell utterly silent.

Then Gaṅgopā, son of Maitrā, spoke to the venerable Mahāmaudgalyāyana and said: "Mahāmaudgalyāyana, answer the girl's question." Mahāmaudgalyāyana replied: "The girl is not asking about what changes. She has asked about the changeless. Now, the changeless and non-conceptual is the awakening of the Tathāgatas — therefore I am unable to answer that."

Then the girl Vimaladattā spoke to Gaṅgopā, son of Maitrā, and said: "Thus, venerable Gaṅgopā, you have been shown by the Blessed One to be foremost among those who teach the Dharma. Now I ask: does the venerable one teach Dharma that has an object of reference, or Dharma that has no object of reference? If he teaches Dharma that has an object of reference, then you are no different from ordinary childish persons — for every ordinary childish person acts on the basis of objects of reference, and thus you, venerable one, are not free from the dharmas of all ordinary childish persons. But if he teaches Dharma that has no object of reference, then the very act of teaching

Dharma would be without substance, which is untenable." Then the venerable Gaṅgopā fell utterly silent.

Then the venerable Mahākāśyapa spoke to Gaṅgopā and said: "Gaṅgopā, answer the girl's question." The venerable Gaṅgopā replied: "The girl is not asking about conventional truth. She has asked about ultimate truth, and I am unable to answer that."

Then the girl Vimaladattā spoke to the venerable Mahākāśyapa and said: "Thus, venerable Mahākāśyapa, it is said that you enter into and arise from the eight liberations, teach Dharma to others, and that all those who have offered you even so little as a ladle-full of alms food will be reborn in the higher realms. Now I ask: does the venerable one purify generosity through the body, or through the mind? If through the body, the body is an inert thing without motion and without agency, like grass, wood, or a wall — like a scarecrow — and as such it cannot purify. If through the mind, the mind is like an illusion, without any stable abiding, and as such it too cannot purify. And if one were to say it is purified through something other than body and mind, that does not exist.

Since it does not exist, how can purification take place? At that point, the venerable Mahākāśyapa fell completely silent and said nothing at all.

Subhūti then spoke: "Venerable Mahākāśyapa, you should answer the question the girl has put to you."

Mahākāśyapa replied: "Girl, it is not I who am being asked about reception. You have asked about the absence of reception, and you are asking about the ultimate limit — and that I am unable to answer."

Then the girl Vimaladattā addressed the elder Subhūti with these words: "Venerable Subhūti, the Blessed One has declared you foremost among those who dwell free from affliction. Now I ask: is that freedom from affliction distinguished by a real thing, or is it distinguished by the nature of reality? If it is distinguished by a real thing, it would become conditioned. If it is distinguished by the nature of reality, then the nature of reality has the defining mark of being without arising and the defining mark of being without cessation. And that which has the defining mark of being without arising and without cessation is evenness itself. That which is evenness is suchness. That which is suchness is without alteration. That which is without alteration is without conventional designation. That which is without conventional designation is inconceivable. That which is inconceivable cannot be pointed

out. That which cannot be pointed out is without any real thing. That which is without any real thing has not come into being. That which has not come into being the noble ones do not teach."

At that, the venerable Subhūti too fell completely silent and said nothing at all.

Then the venerable Nāgasena addressed the venerable Subhūti with these words: "Venerable Subhūti, please answer the question the girl has put to you."

Subhūti spoke in verse:

There is nothing whatsoever here to say.

The one who achieves this achieves the silence.

These Dharma-teachings free from conceptual elaboration —
the girl inquires into them entirely.

For as long as there is arising of real things,
for so long will one be stained by faults.

The dharmadhātu is beyond conventional designation:
this is the mode of being free from affliction.

Then the girl Vimaladattā addressed the venerable Nāgasena with these words: "Venerable Nāgasena, the Blessed One has declared you foremost among those who meditate. Now I ask: does one meditate while abiding in mind, or does one meditate while abiding in the absence of mind? If one meditates while abiding in mind, then mind is beyond expression and is like an illusion — it is a false imputation. Does one then meditate while abiding in what is a false imputation that does not exist? But if one meditates while abiding in the absence of mind, then grass, wood, walls, stones, and all things arisen and disintegrated would all be in meditative absorption. Why? Because all of these are without mind."

Thereupon the venerable Nāgasena fell completely silent and said nothing at all.

Then the venerable Anikṣiptadhura addressed the venerable Nāgasena with these words: "Venerable Nāgasena, please answer the question the girl has put to you."

Nāgasena replied: "Girl, you are inquiring into the domain of the Tathāgatas — this is something that śrāvakas are unable to teach."

The girl said: "Venerable Nāgasena, is the dharmadhātu something other for the Tathāgatas, and yet something other for the śrāvakas? If the dharmadhātu

were different for each, there would be a multiplicity. But suchness is without duality — and if suchness and duality are not distinct, why, venerable Nāgasena, did you say such a thing?"

And Nāgasena too fell completely silent and said nothing at all.

Then the girl Vimaladattā addressed the venerable Anikṣiptadhura with these words:

"Venerable Anikṣiptadhura, the Blessed One has declared you to be the foremost among those with the divine eye. Does the divine eye see things that exist, or does it see things that do not exist? If it sees things that exist, that would amount to the view of eternalism. If it sees things that do not exist, that would amount to the view of annihilation — and neither is acceptable."

And Anikṣiptadhura too said nothing at all.

Then the venerable Ānanda addressed the venerable Anikṣiptadhura with these words: "Venerable Anikṣiptadhura, please answer the girl's question."

The venerable Anikṣiptadhura replied: "The girl has asked something that defeats wisdom altogether — I am unable to answer it."

Then the girl Vimaladattā addressed the venerable Ānanda with these words:

"Venerable Ānanda, the Blessed One has declared you to be the foremost among the greatly learned. Do you regard great learning as pertaining to meaning, or to the letter? If you regard it as pertaining to meaning, then meaning is something that cannot be stated or expressed — it is not known by ear-consciousness, and not known by any consciousness up through mental consciousness. Whatever is of that nature cannot be taught. But if you regard it as pertaining to the letter, the Blessed One has said: 'Rely on meaning, not on the letter.' Therefore, Venerable Ānanda, your great learning is not something to be relied upon."

Then the venerable Ānanda too said nothing at all.

Then the youthful Mañjuśrī addressed the venerable Ānanda with these words: "Venerable Ānanda, please answer the girl's question."

Ānanda replied: "The girl is asking about something beyond letters — it cannot be satisfied by sound and speech. The girl is asking about the equality that is beyond mind — it is not the domain of those still in training. How could it be taught? It must be asked of the Tathāgata, the lord of Dharma."

Then the girl Vimaladattā addressed the youthful Mañjuśrī with these words:

"Mañjuśrī, the Tathāgata has declared you to be the foremost among bodhisattvas who are devoted to the profound. Are you profound because dependent origination is profound, or because your essential nature is profound? If you are profound because dependent origination is profound, then there is no phenomenon whatsoever that is endowed with dependent origination. Why so? Because dependent origination neither goes nor comes, it is not known by eye-consciousness and not known by any consciousness up through mental consciousness, it is without duality, and it is free from arising altogether. But if you are profound because your essential nature is profound, then no essential nature whatsoever can be examined by anyone."

Mañjuśrī replied: "Girl, I am profound because the ultimate limit of reality is profound."

The girl Vimaladattā said: "Mañjuśrī, the ultimate limit of reality is not an extreme — and therefore it is not something to be sought through consciousness."

Mañjuśrī said: "Girl, this term 'ultimate limit of reality' is an expression pointing to the objectless."

The girl Vimaladattā said: "Mañjuśrī, the objectless is not pointed to by any expression — for the objectless perfectly transcends all expression."

Mañjuśrī said: "Girl, how then is this to be taught to others?"

The girl said: "Mañjuśrī, the awakening of the Tathāgatas utterly transcends all teaching — it cannot be shown by words." And Mañjuśrī fell completely silent.

Then the girl Vimaladattā addressed the bodhisattva Amoghadarśin and spoke thus: "Noble son, tell me — whatever men, women, boys, or girls of this city may appear before my eyes, is your intention that all of them shall come to behold the form body of a Tathāgata?" When she had said this, he answered: "Does this mean the Tathāgata is seen as a form body, or as a dharmakāya? If as a form body, that would contradict the word of a buddha — for the Blessed One has declared:

Those who see me as form,
those who know me through sound —
such people, their striving mixed with desire,
shall not truly see me.

And if as the dharmakāya, the dharmakāya cannot be pointed to or shown. Why so? Because the dharmakāya of the Tathāgatas utterly transcends visual consciousness and cannot be looked upon." And Amoghadarśin fell completely silent.

The bodhisattva Ratnakūṭa said: "Amoghadarśin, receive the girl's reply." Amoghadarśin said: "The girl asks about what is without object — and that cannot be shown." The girl Vimaladattā said: "I am asking about neither an object nor the absence of an object. Train in teaching and then teach." And Amoghadarśin fell completely silent.

Then the girl Vimaladattā addressed the bodhisattva Ratnakūṭa and spoke thus: "Noble son, tell me — is your intention that through whoever it may be, treasuries full of jewels shall arise in every household of this city?" When she had said this, he replied: "Does this mean benefiting beings with material things, or benefiting them without material things? If with material things, it would be no different from the benefit given by an ordinary childish person — for the delight of ordinary childish persons is bound up with material things. And if without material things, then what is without material things is not something to be established." And Ratnakūṭa fell completely silent.

Then the girl Vimaladattā addressed the bodhisattva Pāpasūdana and spoke thus: "Noble son, tell me — is your intention that whatever karma sentient beings in this city have accumulated for experiencing the lower realms, they shall instead experience only a minor ripening in this very life?" When she had said this, he replied: "The Tathāgata has taught that karma is inconceivable — and you do not engage it with conceptual thought. If you did, it would contradict the word of the Tathāgata. But if you do not engage it with conceptual thought, then how, without knowing, can you cause karma that would produce many experiences in the lower realms to result in only a minor ripening in this life? That would mean finding a master in phenomena that have no master — and if you acted in that way, it too would contradict the word of the Tathāgata." Pāpasūdana said: "I act through the power of aspiration, causing karma that would produce many experiences in the lower realms to ripen as only a minor experience." The girl said:

"Noble son, the nature of reality of phenomena (dharmatā) cannot be altered by the power of aspiration. If it could, then how is it that the intention of each and every Tathāgata — 'May all sentient beings be utterly liberated from saṃsāra' — fails to be accomplished through the power of aspiration? By this

reasoning, you should understand that it cannot be altered by the power of aspiration." Pāpasūdana fell completely silent.

Then the girl Vimaladattā said this to the bodhisattva Sarvanīvaraṇaviṣkambhin: "Noble son, you declared: 'I shall hold the intention that in such a way all five obscurations of every gathering of people in the great city of Śrāvastī will be dispelled.' Does that meditative absorption depend upon you, or does it depend upon others? If it depends upon you, then it has the character of being immovable — so how, by entering into it yourself, do you bring about the pacification of others' obscurations? If, on the other hand, it depends upon others, then that meditative absorption is not yours. And what is not yours cannot function to benefit others."

The bodhisattva Sarvanīvaraṇaviṣkambhin replied: "Girl, this practice of mine is preceded by loving-kindness."

The girl Vimaladattā said: "Noble son, all the buddhas, the Blessed Ones, abide in loving-kindness — and yet in buddha-fields sentient beings are still harmed by obscurations." Sarvanīvaraṇaviṣkambhin fell completely silent.

Then the girl Vimaladattā said this to the bodhisattva Avalokiteśvara: "Noble son, you declared: 'I shall hold the intention that in such a way all sentient beings in the city who are imprisoned and who are being led away to be executed will be freed, and those who are in danger and threatened by fear will attain fearlessness.' Is this practice of yours with appropriation, or is it without appropriation? If this practice is with appropriation, then ordinary childish persons also possess appropriation, and you would be equal to ordinary childish persons — and so that too is untenable. If, on the other hand, the practice is without appropriation, then it is unconditioned — and what is unconditioned admits of no accomplishment."

Avalokiteśvara fell completely silent.

Then the bodhisattva Sūryagarbha said this to the bodhisattva Avalokiteśvara: "Avalokiteśvara, give an answer to what the girl has asked."

Avalokiteśvara replied: "The girl does not inquire about arising and ceasing, and so I am unable to give an answer."

The girl Vimaladattā said: "Avalokiteśvara, where there is no arising and no ceasing, there is no question."

Avalokiteśvara replied: "Girl, where there is no arising and no ceasing, there is no access through letters."

The girl said: "In all phenomena that are without access and without letters, the wise do not display letters or access, and they are not attached to letters. Non-attachment is the dharmadhātu, and in regard to that, there is no attachment whose purpose would be to realize it."

The bodhisattva Avalokiteśvara, too, fell silent and said nothing.

Then the girl Vimaladattā, having inspired the bodhisattva Prajñāsūra to speak, said this: "Noble son, you have declared: 'I shall contemplate an aspiration of the following kind — that all the multitudes of beings in the city will speak to one another in melodious verse and with a mind of loving-kindness, and will also attain eloquence.' Now, the eloquence that you have thereby accomplished — was it produced by conceptual thought, or did it arise without a cause? If it was produced by conceptual thought, then all conditioned things would likewise be produced by conceptual thought, and in that case they would never be pacified. But if it arose without a cause, that would be to superimpose existence upon what has not arisen."

The bodhisattva Prajñāsūra replied: "Girl, from the very moment of my first arousal of the awakening mind, I planted this aspiration of mine: 'May all sentient beings who appear within the range of my vision attain eloquence.'"

The girl Vimaladattā said: "Noble son, the awakening mind with which you planted that aspiration — does that awakening mind exist, or does it not exist? If it exists, that is an eternalist view. If it does not exist, that is a nihilist view. If you speak in either way, what you say is mistaken."

The bodhisattva Prajñāsūra also fell silent and said nothing.

Then the girl Vimaladattā spoke to the bodhisattva Arthavighraha, saying: "Noble son, you have declared: 'I shall contemplate an aspiration of the following kind — that no matter where I am in this city, all the sentient beings who appear within the range of my vision will become irreversible from unsurpassed, complete, and perfect awakening.' Now, regarding this — shall we say that awakening exists, or shall we say that it does not exist? If it exists, it is eternal — that is, grasping at the extreme of existence. If it does not exist, it is annihilated — that is, grasping at the extreme of non-existence."

The bodhisattva Arthavighraha replied: "Girl, the word 'awakening' is a term that points to wisdom."

The girl Vimaladattā said: "Is that wisdom distinguished by arising, or is it distinguished by cessation? If it is distinguished by arising, it would be a

conditioned thing produced by improper attention, and such knowing belongs to childish ordinary people. If it is distinguished by cessation, then there is no object of reference with respect to it. And where there is no object of reference, there arises no conceptual thought of 'this is an ordinary person,' or 'this is a śrāvaka,' or 'this is a pratyekabuddha,' or 'this is a bodhisattva,' or 'this is a buddha.' And why is that? Because awakening is non-conceptual, childish ordinary people conceptualize about awakening, while the wise do not — precisely because it is non-conceptual."

The bodhisattva Arthavigraha also fell silent and said nothing.

Then the venerable Subhūti said to those bodhisattvas: "Let us not proceed further into the city for alms, but turn back. And why? Because the Dharma we have heard today from the girl Vimaladattā is the food of the wise and will bring satisfaction. Let us eat this food of Dharma."

Then the girl Vimaladattā said to the elder Subhūti: "Venerable Subhūti, where there is nothing to add and —"

nothing to put in place — what, then, do you think you are seeking? Venerable Subhūti, the way of the renunciant is to be free of conceptual elaboration, not to delight in elaboration. Venerable Subhūti, the way of the Dharma for the renunciant is to have no fixed abiding and to make no abiding — for the domain of the noble ones is undisturbed."

This is the second and final fascicle.

Then those eight great śrāvakas, those eight bodhisattvas, those roughly five hundred brahmins, the girl Vimaladattā, King Prasenajit, and the great mass of other people all went to where the Blessed One was. Having arrived, they bowed their heads to the feet of the Blessed One, circumambulated him three times, and took their seats to one side.

Then the girl Vimaladattā circumambulated the Blessed One a thousand times, draped her shawl over one shoulder, placed her right knee on the ground, turned toward where the Blessed One was, pressed her palms together, and with melodious verse offered this petition:

You who possess the power of samādhi, whose fame is boundless,
Protector of the world, who grants the nectar of delight,
To you, the Sugata of matchless primordial wisdom, I petition:
How does a bodhisattva engage in the conduct of awakening?

How, standing at the foot of the king of trees, does one vanquish the māras?
How does one cause the earth, together with Mount Meru, to tremble?
How does one of boundless fame send forth rays of light?
Please, teach well the manner of conduct leading to awakening.

How does one obtain the dhāraṇī that is the treasure of the buddhas?
How does one cultivate the supreme, peaceful meditative absorption?
How does a person obtain the power of miraculous ability?
Speak of the conduct of those precious sentient beings.

Through what does one become endowed with mindfulness, understanding,
and intelligence?

Through what does one become possessed of beautiful eloquence?
Being endowed with what, does one speak within an assembly
Words that are melodious and very lovely?

Through what does a person come to remember past lives,
And also obtain the pure divine eye free of stain?
Through what does one obtain the divine ear and know the minds of others?
Through miraculous power, does one travel to a hundred fields?

How does one become diligent in the practice of generosity?
How does one always maintain pure ethical discipline and delight in patience?
How does one become skilled in diligence and meditative concentration?
And how does one strive ardently also in wisdom?

How, having completely abandoned birth from a womb,
Does one always take birth spontaneously from a lotus?
How does one come to be present before the buddhas
And proclaim the words of selflessness and emptiness?

How does one become such that pleasure and displeasure are equal,
Craving abandoned, aversion toward the lowly relinquished?
No thought of being high, no thought of being low,
The mind steady and unmoving, like Mount Meru?

Gain and no-gain, fame and no-fame,
Praise and blame, pleasure and suffering —
How does one remain, having overcome the dharmas of the world,
Moving through all the world like the moon?

No pretense of egolessness, no deceit,
How does one, free of dust, abandon pride and arrogance?

Peaceful, utterly peaceful, devoted to calm abiding —
How does the wise one attain the highest primordial wisdom?

No delight in wife, children, wealth, or beloved,
How does one find true joy in a bed at the forest's edge?
Always equal to a bird, similar to the moon —
How does one delight in and aspire to the wealth of the Dharma?

Equal to water, like the earth, equal to the wind —
How does the wise one become like fire?
Always without any thing, free of conceptual thought,
Delighting in evenness, equal to the sky —

How does one never abandon the Dharma,
Forsaking self while not relinquishing the supreme Dharma?
Having aroused the intention to be a teacher in the worlds,
How does one abide and engage in the pursuit of awakening?

How does one come to abide in the array of a pure field?
How does the Saṅgha become pure?
How does one hear the Dharma in all three times, and —

How do sentient beings come to have long life and happiness?
Always reaching the far shore that puts craving to rest,
How does one, having tamed the foe, see the Four Truths?
How does one place hundreds of sentient beings in awakening?

How does one come to act and always be filled with joy and delight?
By what means does one become supremely beautiful?
By what means does one come to take birth by miraculous transformation?

With great wealth and great wisdom,
How does one penetrate and inwardly realize omniscience?
By what means does one attain the thirty-two major marks
And the eighty minor marks of excellence?

Skilled in all accumulation of merit —
By what means is that eloquence born?
How does one come to delight in the pure field?

The Saṅgha of monks, perfectly complete —

Wherever one has planted an aspiration,
How does one come to be born there?

How does one come to remember past lives?

How does one come to meet the buddhas?
Throughout ten thousand millions of aeons,
How does one never fall into the lower realms?
As a perfect guide, how does one
Obtain beauty, splendor, and renown?
Strength and power and diligence —
How does one come not to be exhausted by these?
How does one take refuge
In the buddhas, the Dharma, and the Saṅgha,
Surrendering body and life,
Yet never abandoning their Dharma?
How does one practice the conduct of awakening
And become free of all doubt?
Having abandoned all remorse,
Teaching the Dharma to living beings —
There is nothing you do not know:
O Great Sage, you are omniscient.
Please teach in due order
The conduct of the bodhisattva.

When she had spoken thus, the Blessed One said this to the girl Vimaladattā:
Excellent, excellent, my girl! It is excellent of you to think to ask the Tathāgata
about matters such as these. Therefore, listen well, hold it in mind, and I will
explain.

Vimaladattā replied to the Blessed One, "Excellent!" and turned her face
toward the Blessed One to listen. The Blessed One then spoke as follows:

My girl, when a bodhisattva possesses four qualities, the bodhisattva tames
māra. What are the four? Not being envious of what others have gained;
completely abandoning divisive speech; leading many people to take up the
roots of virtue; and cultivating loving-kindness that is without obscuration. My
girl, when a bodhisattva possesses these four qualities, the bodhisattva tames
māra. Regarding this, it is said:

Do not be envious; do not speak divisively.
Apply yourself to bringing the many to virtue.
Cultivating loving-kindness throughout the ten directions,
One tames māra here and touches awakening.

My girl, when a bodhisattva possesses four qualities, the bodhisattva shakes innumerable buddha-fields. What are the four? Acting just as one has spoken; having devoted interest in the profound Dharma; being steadfast in one's commitments; and leading many people to genuinely take hold of awakening. My girl, when a bodhisattva possesses these four qualities, the bodhisattva shakes innumerable buddha-fields. Regarding this, it is said:

One acts just as one has spoken.

The wise one bears with patient acceptance the profound Dharma.

One is supremely steadfast in one's commitments,

And leads beings into the white qualities.

One gladdens the many toward unsurpassed and perfect awakening.

By means of these four qualities,

One shakes tens of millions of fields.

My girl, when a bodhisattva possesses four qualities, the bodhisattva sends out rays of light throughout innumerable and boundless buddha-fields. What are the four? Offering lamps; thoroughly upholding the sacred Dharma; going to those sentient beings who have become heedless and found themselves without the opportune conditions, and teaching them the Dharma; and covering the stūpas of the Tathāgatas with nets of precious gems.

My girl, when a bodhisattva possesses those four qualities, the bodhisattva sends out rays of light throughout innumerable and boundless buddha-fields. And concerning this, the following is said:

By offering lamps, the light becomes utterly pure.

In times of decline, one thoroughly upholds the sacred Dharma.

One gives Dharma to those who have become heedless.

One offers nets of precious gems upon the stūpas.

Thus does the bodhisattva travel through tens of millions of inconceivable fields,

Sending out rays of light.

When those rays touch them, sentient beings come to dwell in bliss.

The wise one pursues the aim of unsurpassed awakening.

My girl, when a bodhisattva possesses four qualities, the bodhisattva attains dhāraṇī (Skt. dhāraṇī). What are the four? Giving an assortment of pure and immaculate ornaments; my girl, adorning oneself with every kind of ornament and giving them to those who beg; ceaselessly reciting the praises of the Tathāgatas; and dwelling extensively in the Perfection of Wisdom. My girl,

when a bodhisattva possesses those four qualities, the bodhisattva attains dhāraṇī. And concerning this, the following is said:

By giving an assortment of things, one attains dhāraṇī.
My girl, she adorns herself and gives to those who beg.
Without ceasing, she recites the praises of the buddhas.
She cultivates wisdom for the sake of the Victors' gnosis.

By these four qualities, one attains dhāraṇī.
Even over a hundred aeons, what one has heard is not forgotten.
Whatever Tathāgatas teach throughout the ten directions,
All of it is held by the power of mindfulness.

My girl, when a bodhisattva possesses four qualities, the bodhisattva attains meditative absorption (samādhi). What are the four? Being greatly disenchanted with cyclic existence; delighting in and being devoted to solitude; having aroused diligence; and having thoroughly and fully brought the ends of action to completion. My girl, when a bodhisattva possesses those four qualities, the bodhisattva attains meditative absorption. And concerning this, the following is said:

One is disenchanted with all wandering through existence.
Like a rhinoceros horn, one delights in moving about alone.
Always and exceedingly, one has aroused diligence.
One's actions are always brought to utter completion.

Ever having entered into these four qualities,
One swiftly seeks the peaceful conduct of awakening.
The bodhisattva gains a foothold in meditative absorption,
And realizes awakening, the domain of the Victors.

My girl, when a bodhisattva possesses four qualities, the bodhisattva attains miraculous powers (Skt. ṛddhi). What are the four? Lightness of body; lightness of mind; having no fixation upon any phenomenon whatsoever; and blessing the four elements to be equal to the element of space. My girl, when a bodhisattva possesses those four qualities, the bodhisattva attains miraculous powers. And concerning this, the following is said:

Lightness of body, and likewise lightness of mind;
Non-abiding with respect to all phenomena;
Being equal and alike to the element of space —
One blesses the four elements accordingly.

If one genuinely relies upon these four qualities,
That person of intelligence attains boundless miraculous powers.
In a single instant one travels to a thousand fields
And beholds the many thousands of buddhas.

My girl, when a bodhisattva possesses four qualities, the bodhisattva becomes beautiful. What are the four? Being free of anger, quarreling, spite, and aversion; being zealously devoted to paying homage at the stūpas of the Tathāgatas; being restrained by the vow of moral discipline and always saying to those who approach, "Welcome, well come!"; and having no frowning or hostile mind toward those who teach the Dharma. My girl, when a bodhisattva possesses those four qualities, the bodhisattva becomes beautiful. And concerning this, the following is said:

One does not become angry or bear grudges toward others.
Free of arrogance, conceit, spite, and aversion.
One loves non-quarreling and speaks pleasingly.

One reverently pays homage at the stūpas of the Victors.
One always guards moral discipline in its purity.
One always says to those who come, "Welcome, well come!"
And toward those who teach the Dharma, one has no frowning.
Such a one's mind is like a vajra mountain, unshakeable.

My girl, when a bodhisattva possesses four qualities, the bodhisattva will be born by miraculous apparitional birth. What are these four? Causing Tathāgata images to be enshrined upon lotuses, and filling one's hands with utpala flowers, lotuses, and white lotuses to scatter as offerings before the Tathāgata or before stūpas of the Tathāgata; possessing the disposition of one who delights genuinely and abundantly in benefiting others; not grasping at the faults of others; and fully dedicating all roots of virtue to the awakening of the buddhas for the sake of benefiting and bringing happiness to all sentient beings. My girl, when a bodhisattva possesses these four qualities, the bodhisattva will be born by miraculous apparitional birth. And concerning this, the following is said:

One causes the buddha's image to be enshrined upon a supreme lotus.
Filling one's hands with water-born flowers, one makes offerings.
One also speaks words that generate joy in others.
Making them joyful, with earnest effort, one grasps not at faults.
For the benefit of all beings, one fully dedicates merit.

Knowing how to accomplish the awakening of the buddhas, supreme sages,
If one relies on these four qualities spoken by the buddhas,
One will be born miraculously in the presence of the supreme Victors.

My girl, when a bodhisattva possesses four qualities, the bodhisattva will come to enjoy great wealth. What are these four? Giving generously without contempt; relinquishing all possessions without attachment; being endowed with great devotion; and being free of all wrong views. My girl, when a bodhisattva possesses these four qualities, the bodhisattva will come to enjoy great wealth. And concerning this, the following is said:

Such a one gives generously, without contempt in giving.
Such a one never grasps always at things as possessions.
Having aroused devotion toward the supreme wisdom of the Victors,
Such a one will henceforth attain great wealth and prosperity.
One will be endowed with faith, be free of deceit and guile.
One will not come to grasp at the faults of others.
Whoever has straightened their view through superior intention,
That one, in this very life, is endowed with excellent prosperity.

My girl, when a bodhisattva possesses four qualities, the bodhisattva will come to have great wisdom. What are these four? Not being miserly toward the Dharma; dispelling remorse by not engaging in what is contrary; teaching correct oral instructions precisely as they are to those who ask; and dwelling extensively in the cultivation of emptiness. My girl, when a bodhisattva possesses these four qualities, the bodhisattva will come to have great wisdom. And concerning this, the following is said:

The wise one never becomes miserly.
Free of engagement in what is contrary, one dispels remorse.
One teaches oral instructions that are perfectly and fully sound.
One cultivates emptiness, which is the conduct of the Victors.
If one relies with certainty on these four qualities,
One swiftly attains the awakening desired by the Victors.
Having been guided by the buddhas and having trained,
One will become a buddha, the supreme among bipeds.

My girl, when a bodhisattva possesses four qualities, the bodhisattva will come to remember past lives. What are these four? Receiving scriptural transmissions; reciting and teaching transmissions to those diligent in

recitation, and when those who have forgotten oral instructions after a long time have passed and then come to ask, reciting the transmissions and causing them to remember; winning others' trust and closeness through words of joy and delight in just this way; definitive emergence from the suffering of saṃsāra; and

and teaching the Dharma to others so that they may attain the bliss of nirvāṇa; striving earnestly in dedication, and being skilled in the signs of meditative absorption. My girl, when a bodhisattva possesses these four qualities, the bodhisattva will come to remember past lives.

Concerning this, the following is said:

One recites transmissions, causing the forgetful to remember.

One proclaims pleasing words to others as well.

One teaches the Dharma without weariness.

One holds well to the signs of cultivating absorption.

If one steadfastly relies upon these four qualities,
One possessed of great power will remember past lives,
Recalling innumerable aeons stretching back a thousandfold,
And will swiftly attain the supreme state of the highest guide.

My girl, when a bodhisattva possesses four qualities, the bodhisattva will come to meet with buddhas. What are these four? Not abandoning the sacred Dharma even at the cost of one's life; not associating with evil companions even at the cost of one's life; not speaking ill of those who teach the Dharma even at the cost of one's life; and cultivating the meditative absorption of recollecting the buddhas. My girl, when a bodhisattva possesses these four qualities, the bodhisattva will come to meet with buddhas.

Concerning this, the following is said:

One does not abandon the awakening of the buddhas.

One does not speak ill of those who teach the Dharma.

Therefore one utterly relinquishes evil companions.

Without slackening, one recollects the buddhas always.

If one steadfastly relies upon these four qualities,
One thereby attains meeting with the Sugatas.
Until unsurpassable awakening is reached,
Wherever a guide resides, there will one be born.

My girl, when a bodhisattva possesses four qualities, the bodhisattva will attain the thirty-two major marks of a great being. What are these four? Scattering precious jewels over Tathāgatas and over their stūpas; washing the stūpas of the Tathāgata with fragrant oils and grains; offering flowers, incense, and various kinds of music; and serving and attending upon abbots and preceptors with a pleasant retinue. My girl, when a bodhisattva possesses these four qualities, the bodhisattva will attain the thirty-two major marks of a great being.

Concerning this, the following is said:

One scatters precious gems upon the stūpa.

One washes the stūpa with fragrant oils and grains.

One offers incense, flowers, and various kinds of music.

With pleasantness one attends upon abbots and preceptors.

That one's body will be adorned with thirty-two marks,

Supremely beautiful and endowed with every excellence.

By these qualities, through whom the highest wisdom adorns the Victor,

One comes to bear the marks of a great being.

My girl, when a bodhisattva possesses four qualities, the bodhisattva will attain the eighty minor marks of excellence. What are these four? Offering various materials as seats for the Dharma; showing reverence to others without weariness; not disputing with those who teach the Dharma; and leading sentient beings to take hold of authentic awakening. My girl, when a bodhisattva possesses these four qualities, the bodhisattva will attain the eighty minor marks of excellence.

Concerning this, the following is said:

One offers various materials as a seat for the Dharma.

One shows reverence to others without growing weary.

One does not enter into dispute with those who teach the Dharma.

One leads sentient beings to take hold of awakening.

Through these four, the excellent minor marks upon one's body

Are here found without difficulty by that one.

If one constantly relies upon these qualities,

This bodhisattva will here be adorned with them.

My girl, when a bodhisattva possesses four qualities, the bodhisattva will attain eloquence. What are these four? Upholding the scriptural collection of

the bodhisattvas, and

reciting day and night the categories of the Dharma of the three aggregates, taking hold with supreme joy of the certainty that the awakening of the buddhas, the Blessed Ones, is unborn and unceasing, utterly unlike anything in all the world, and not regarding body, life, or possessions. My girl, when a bodhisattva possesses these four qualities, the bodhisattva will attain eloquence.

Concerning this, it is said:

The scriptural collection of the bodhisattvas

One recites continuously, day and night.

What is unlike all the world

One proclaims without weariness.

Having found supreme joy,

One upholds the teaching of the buddhas.

Without regard for body or for life,

One gazes toward awakening.

If one constantly relies upon these four,

That one's eloquence will grow and flourish,

Satisfying all the world with its gods

As though with garlands of every kind.

My girl, when a bodhisattva possesses four qualities, the bodhisattva will attain a perfectly pure buddha-field. What are these four? Having no jealousy, having no miserliness, holding an even mind toward all sentient beings, and not mingling with retinues. My girl, when a bodhisattva possesses these four qualities, the bodhisattva will attain a perfectly pure buddha-field.

Concerning this, it is said:

One never feels jealousy toward another's gains.

On seeing them, one rejoices, free of miserliness.

That one's mind is even toward every sentient being.

That one does not come to mingle with retinues.

Through these four qualities one attains the splendor of a pure field,

And will swiftly attain the supreme awakening.

My girl, when a bodhisattva possesses four qualities, the bodhisattva will attain an excellent and pure Saṅgha. What are these four? Not dividing another's retinue, reconciling those who are at odds, benefiting others by

guiding them to receive scriptural transmission and to recite it, and completely abandoning divisive speech. My girl, when a bodhisattva possesses these four qualities, the bodhisattva will attain an excellent and pure Saṅgha.

Concerning this, it is said:

One never comes to divide another's retinue.

One brings together people who are at odds.

One guides others rightly in receiving transmission and recitation.

One speaks no divisive words to those on the other side.

If one steadfastly relies on these four qualities,

One will attain a vast and perfectly pure Saṅgha.

Therefore, in order to purify the Saṅgha,

The wise should always rely upon this Dharma.

My girl, when a bodhisattva possesses four qualities, the bodhisattva will be reborn in whatever buddha-field the mind of awakening was first aroused in. What are these four? Not giving rise to jealousy toward the learning, the advantage, or the gains of others; seeking with superior intention the complete purity of the six perfections; cultivating the perception that all bodhisattvas are teachers, and showing respect even to a bodhisattva who has just first aroused the mind of awakening; and having no pretense for the sake of advantage in learning. My girl, when a bodhisattva possesses these four qualities, the bodhisattva will be reborn in whatever buddha-field the mind of awakening was first aroused in.

Concerning this, it is said:

When one sees offerings given to another, one feels no jealousy.

One seeks the complete purity of the perfections.

One always thinks of bodhisattvas as teachers.

One uses no pretense for the sake of the ease of learning's advantage.

If one always relies upon these qualities,

One will come to meet the Tathāgatas themselves,

And in whichever field one has set forth aspirations,

One will be reborn in that very field according to one's wish.

Then the girl Vimaladattā addressed the Blessed One with these words:

"Blessed One, if I do not truly take up and abide by these qualities of the Dharma just as the Blessed One has set them forth, then may I have deceived all the buddhas, the Blessed Ones, who dwell and abide throughout the

world-systems of the ten directions, teaching the Dharma."

Then the venerable Mahāmaudgalyāyana said this to the girl Vimaladattā: "Girl, what you say is remarkable. Do you not know that the bodhisattva conduct of bodhisattvas is difficult to accomplish?"

Then the girl Vimaladattā said this to the elder Mahāmaudgalyāyana: "Venerable Mahāmaudgalyāyana, by whatever truth and words of truth through which, in a future time, I shall become a Tathāgata, an arhat, a perfectly and fully awakened buddha, just as the Tathāgata now abides face to face before us, and by which I shall truly take up and abide in these qualities of the Dharma just as they have been set forth — by that truth and those words of truth, may this great trichiliocosm tremble in six ways, with no harm coming to any sentient being! And by whatever truth and words of truth through which I shall truly take up and abide in these qualities of the Dharma just as they have been set forth by the Blessed One — by that truth and those words of truth, may a rain of divine flowers fall openly, and may tens of billions of unstrung cymbals ring out! And may I, too, be transformed from a woman's body and be reborn in a man's body, appearing like a youth of sixteen years!"

The moment she had made that aspiration and performed this act of truth's blessing, in that very instant the great trichiliocosm trembled in six ways, the sound of tens of billions of unstrung cymbals arose, and a rain of divine flowers fell openly. And the girl Vimaladattā's woman's body became invisible, and she appeared as a young man who had attained male faculties and seemed to be just sixteen years of age.

Then the venerable Mahāmaudgalyāyana addressed the Blessed One with these words: "Blessed One, bodhisattvas are truly wondrous! Blessed One, I pay homage to the bodhisattva from the first arousing of the mind of awakening up through dwelling at the heart of awakening. Why is that? Because through this act of truth's blessing, each and every one of these causes has been perfectly fulfilled, and the girl Vimaladattā has become thus renowned for her great miraculous power, thus renowned for her great dominion, and has shown herself thus possessed of great might."

The Blessed One declared: "Maudgalyāyana, it is indeed so. It is exactly as has been said. Bodhisattvas from the first arousing of the mind of awakening up through the heart of awakening are objects of veneration and fields of generosity for the world together with its gods, and they surpass all śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas entirely."

Then the Blessed One at that moment smiled. This is the nature of reality (dharmatā) for all buddhas, the Blessed Ones: whenever the Blessed One smiles, rays of light of many and various colors — blue, yellow, red, white, the color of crystal, and the color of silver — issue forth from the Blessed One's mouth,

those rays of light illuminated and pervaded countless and boundless world-realms in every direction, rose up as far as the Brahmā worlds, and then returned and were absorbed into the crown of the Blessed One's head.

Then the venerable Ānanda rose from his seat, drew his outer robe over one shoulder, placed his right knee on the ground, and, turning toward the Blessed One, joined his palms together and bowed. He then addressed the Blessed One in verse:

Your voice is as the voice of gods and Brahmā, as the voice of the Lord of the Mimi, and as the resonant roll of thunder.

O Protector, your voice is pleasing as a god's, and you are the one who stills attachment and aversion.

You who abandon delusion, you who generate measureless and supreme joy in the worlds —

you who possess the ten powers and an ocean of qualities: for whose sake was this light displayed? Please tell us.

Mountains together with their forests, trees, waters, and lands all trembled in six ways.

The gods dwelling in the sky let fall a delightful rain of divine flowers.

As a lion defeats a fox, so you have defeated all non-Buddhists (tīrthikas) and every other opponent.

O Hero, for whose great and excellent benefit was this auspicious omen of light displayed? Please tell us.

The light of ten billion suns and moons spread wide, together with the lights of lightning and of jewels,

and the lights of gods, nāgas, gandharvas, and yakṣas blazed in their brilliance —

yet when they encountered the virtuous and pure light that issued from the mouth of Śākyamuni,

all those lights were utterly eclipsed, and the light of the Buddha beautified the ten directions.

The tuft of hair between your brows shines forth supremely beautiful, white, immaculate, and excellent.

Blazing, it illuminates all directions, resembling the stalk of a lotus, a conch shell, and the kunda flower.

Having eclipsed all others, the Victor is resplendent like the firefly of a parasol. O lion among men, O Sage, for whose sake and for what great and excellent purpose this has come to pass — please tell us.

When he had spoken thus, the Blessed One said this to the venerable Ānanda: "Ānanda, do you see how the girl Vimaladattā, through the power of whose blessing the substance of womanhood has been transformed and the faculty of maleness has been obtained?"

Ānanda said: "Blessed One, I do see."

The Blessed One declared: "Ānanda, the bodhisattva Vimaladattā has practiced for the sake of unsurpassed and perfect awakening for eighty hundred thousand incalculable eons. Having practiced for sixty hundred thousand incalculable eons, this girl was then caused to arouse the mind of unsurpassed and perfect awakening by Mañjuśrī in his youth. Whatever array of buddha-field qualities belonging to eighty thousand bodhisattvas such as youthful Mañjuśrī may exist — all of that array of buddha-field qualities will be united with the array of buddha-field qualities of the bodhisattva Vimaladattā."

Then the venerable Mahāmaudgalyāyana said this to the bodhisattva Vimaladattā: "Son of good family, you have been practicing for so long a time for the sake of unsurpassed and perfect awakening. Why then have you not at that time transformed the substance of womanhood?" The bodhisattva Vimaladattā replied: "The venerable Mahāmaudgalyāyana is held to be the foremost among those who possess supernatural powers. Why, venerable one, have you not transformed your male body?" The venerable Mahāmaudgalyāyana fell silent.

Then the bodhisattva, the great being Vimaladattā, said this to Mahāmaudgalyāyana: "Venerable Mahāmaudgalyāyana, awakening is not fully and perfectly realized by means of a woman's body, nor is it fully and perfectly realized by means of a man's body. And why is that?"

Awakening is unborn; and since it cannot be fully and perfectly realized by means of either body or mind, that is why this is so.

Then the bodhisattva Mañjuśrī addressed the Blessed One with these words: "Blessed One, it is truly wonderful that the bodhisattva Vimaladattā should have such deep faith and devotion." The Blessed One declared: "Mañjuśrī, this bodhisattva Vimaladattā has lived the pure and holy life in the presence of six hundred million buddhas. She has cultivated meditative absorption on emptiness. For eighty eons she has cultivated patience with the truth of non-arising. She has thoroughly inquired into the Perfection of Wisdom from thirty million buddhas and from bodhisattvas endowed with profound understanding. She has honored eighty million buddhas with robes and food. And she has thoroughly inquired into this enumeration of Dharma teachings that sets forth the full resolution of confidence.

"Mañjuśrī, if a son or daughter of good family were to fill as many world systems of the great trichiliocosm as there are grains of sand in the Ganges River with the seven precious substances and offer them to the Tathāgatas, arhats, fully and perfectly awakened buddhas, the merit produced would be surpassed by that of any son or daughter of good family who hears this enumeration of Dharma teachings, takes it up, retains it, keeps it, reads it, masters it fully, or extensively and rightly teaches it to others. And why is that? Because this practice leads to the attainment of awakening.

Then the Blessed One again spoke to the youthful Mañjuśrī: "Mañjuśrī, take up this enumeration of Dharma teachings, hold it close, imbibe it fully, master it completely, and extensively and rightly teach it to others as well."

Then the youthful Mañjuśrī addressed the Blessed One with these words: "Blessed One, what is the name of this enumeration of Dharma teachings, and how should I take it up?" The Blessed One declared: "Mañjuśrī, therefore take up this enumeration of Dharma teachings under the name 'The Full Resolution of Confidence.' Take it up also under the name 'The Vajra Words of Dhāraṇī.' Take it up also under the name 'The Scriptural Collection of the Bodhisattvas.' And take it up also under the name 'The Questions of Vimaladattā.'

When the Blessed One taught this enumeration of Dharma teachings, eighty trillion living beings from among the gods and humans were decisively established toward unsurpassable, fully and perfectly accomplished awakening.

Then the bodhisattva Prabhāsaśrī addressed the Blessed One with these words: "Blessed One, when will the bodhisattva Vimaladattā fully and perfectly realize unsurpassable, fully and perfectly accomplished awakening?" The

Blessed One declared: "Son of good family, after incalculable hundreds of thousands of eons have passed beyond reckoning, the bodhisattva Vimaladattā will become a Tathāgata, an arhat, a fully and perfectly awakened buddha in a buddha-field that has no śrāvakas or pratyekabuddhas, whose lifespan is immeasurable, which is attended by an immeasurable Saṅgha of bodhisattvas, which is endowed with enjoyments far surpassing those of the gods, and which is arrayed with immeasurable qualities — and that Tathāgata will be known as Immaculate Crest King, the Smiling and Joyful One."

Then the bodhisattva Vimaladattā, having heard the prophecy of her future awakening directly from the Blessed One, was filled with joy and

exhilarated to the utmost, she rose up into the sky to the height of eighty thousand tāla trees, and, filling a thousand buddha-fields with light, she consecrated a jeweled canopy measuring eighty-four thousand leagues that she placed above the crown of the Blessed One's head — and that jeweled canopy covered this great trichiliocosm. There in the sky she performed immeasurable miraculous displays, and then praised, saluted, and paid homage to all the buddhas of the ten directions, as numerous as the grains of sand in the Ganges river, before descending from the sky, circumambulating the Blessed One a thousand times, and taking her seat to one side.

Then those five hundred brahmins, beginning with the brahmin Brahmadeva, witnessed both the miraculous display performed by the bodhisattva Vimaladattā and heard the prophecy of her awakening. Filled with satisfaction and delight, they rejoiced and were overcome with happiness and gladness of mind. Pressing their palms together toward the Blessed One in the direction where he sat, they addressed the Blessed One with these verses, speaking in one harmonious voice:

Those who are devoted to the buddhas,
and whose minds are fully resolved
upon the Dharma of the buddhas —
they have obtained the supreme gain.

Because in former times we committed sinful deeds,
we were born into brahmin households.
When we saw the hearers (śrāvakas) of the Teacher,
we uttered the word "inauspicious."

When we saw the sons of the buddhas, the bodhisattvas,
and called them "inauspicious" —

whatever words we spoke in that way,
Venerable One, we now confess that transgression.

Those people who have not seen the buddhas,
supreme and excellent kings of assemblies,
they have obtained only transgression,
and they seek after poor food.

When Vimaladattā invited us as guests
to offer the sacrifice in her honor,
we sat there disrespectfully
when we saw the hearers of the Teacher.

And when she asked us,
"Where have you seen your guide?"
she said that seven days after her birth,
she went to hear the name of a buddha.

She told how that buddha was greatly praised,
and said that she would never be otherwise —
and hearing her words, all of us
entered fully into the supreme awakening.

It is for the sake of our past merit
and roused by the word "buddha"
that we have come here
to bow at the feet of the Śākya Lion.

We have seen and saluted the perfectly awakened buddha,
and have been able to hear the supreme Dharma.
By seeing this most excellent of two-footed beings,
we are liberated from all suffering.

Whatever Dharma teachings the protector Śākya Lion
has given and proclaimed —
for the sake of the Dharma of the buddhas
we will train ourselves in those teachings.

In order to attain the Dharma of the buddhas,
having heard of the conduct of awakening,
we will, with genuine diligence,
train ourselves in that very conduct.

We will abide with earnest effort
in whatever conduct, path, and gateway
of the bodhisattvas is taught,
and we will become objects of veneration for the world.

Knowing their superior aspiration,
the Sage at that moment smiled.
They requested the great Sage:
"Grant us your prophecy!"

And Ānanda asked it of the Buddha.
The Blessed One then spoke to Ānanda these words:

These five hundred brahmins
and that brahmin Brahmadeva —
all of them, within the span of a single eon,
will become buddhas, the supreme guides.

They who in past lives paid homage
to a full five hundred buddhas,
from that time onward, throughout their lives,
will see tens of millions of buddhas.

For eighty eons upon eons,
they will not go to the lower realms.
In each and every eon,
they will see tens of millions of buddhas.

In that single eon of theirs,
they will become the supreme among two-footed beings.

In the eon called Luminous Maker,
they will come to bear the name Brahmā's Voice.
Their lifespans will be equal in measure —
lasting eighty eons upon eons.

Their buddha-fields will be equal, their Saṅghas equal,
each with eighty tens of millions of monks.
Serving the welfare of sentient beings
and practicing this very Dharma as well,
all of them, in due succession,
will attain the peace of nirvāṇa.

When the Blessed One had spoken these words, the bodhisattva Spobs pa Brtsegs, the bodhisattva Vimaladatta, the youthful Mañjuśrī, those brahmins, King Prasenajit, those great śrāvakas, and the world with its gods, humans, asuras, and gandharvas rejoiced and offered fervent praise at what the Blessed One had taught.

This concludes the chapter entitled "Requested by Vimaladatta," being the thirty-third chapter of the noble Great Jewel Heap Dharma-discourse in one hundred thousand sections.

Translated from Sanskrit by the Indian master Jinamitra and Surendrabodhi, and revised by the great editor

Translator's Notes

- The names of the bodhisattvas in the assembly present a genuine challenge, as several are rendered in Tibetan translation rather than transliterated from Sanskrit, and some are epithets rather than proper names. The renderings used here follow standard scholarly identification of these figures: for example, Ratnāloka for rin chen 'od, Prajñārāśi for shes rab brtseg, Śrīgarbha for dpal gyi snying po, Yaśomati for grags pa'i blo gros, Pratibhānarāśi for spobs pa brtseg, Aśokadatta for mya ngan med kyi byin, Sarvāvaraṇaviśkambhin for sgrib pa thams cad rnam par sel ba, Asaṅgamati for sems thogs pa med pa, Vikrāntacārin Amogha for gom pa 'dor ba don yod, and Darśanāmogha for mthong ba don yod. Where a figure appears both in the hearers' list and the bodhisattvas' list, the same rendering has been retained for consistency. The phrase describing all monks as having reached "the very summit of perfect mastery over every power of mind, with a single exception, namely the venerable Ānanda," follows the standard commentarial reading that Ānanda had not yet attained arhatship at the time of the assembly.

- The bodhisattva name rendered "Remover of Evil Rebirths" translates the Tibetan literally as one who causes evil destinies to be abandoned. The name "Meaningful Sight" similarly translates a standard epithet meaning one whose seeing is not in vain. These are less commonly attested bodhisattva figures; their names are translated from the Tibetan as given, since no established Sanskrit equivalents have been identified for this list with certainty.

The five obscurations referred to are the standard set: desire, malice, sloth-and-torpor, restlessness-and-remorse, and doubt.

- The constellation Uttarāṣāḍhā renders Tibetan "rgyal" (literally "the King" or "victorious one"), which is the standard Tibetan name for the lunar mansion Uttarāṣāḍhā. This is a genuinely technical astrological term and the identification is secure.

The name Brahmadeva renders "Tshangs pa'i lha," literally "the god of Brahmā" or "Brahmā-god." This is used here as a brahmin's proper name, not as a reference to the deity Brahmā, and has been rendered accordingly as a personal name.

- The phrase rendered "the hair of his body is concealed within the skin" refers to the traditional major mark (lakṣaṇa) that each of the body's hairs curls back into its pore, sometimes described in terms of the smoothness of the skin like that of a thoroughbred horse. The Tibetan comparison to a "supreme horse" and the subsequent "pores like gold" refer to two distinct major and minor marks of a great being.

The term "eina deer" renders the Tibetan "e-na" (āṇeya in Sanskrit), a deer with especially well-formed, auspicious legs, a standard simile for the well-proportioned feet and calves of a buddha.

The line "he does not reveal wrongdoing" (mi 'byed sdig pa med) could alternatively be rendered "he does not expose the faults of others" — the sense is that his speech never lays bare another's failings or causes harm. This is doctrinally significant as one of the qualities of right speech.

- The phrase rendered "half the wisdom of men" translates the Tibetan literally: "women are second in wisdom" or "wisdom at the second level." The traditional commentarial reading is that women's wisdom is considered half that of men — a conventional doctrinal formulation found across numerous Indian Buddhist texts. This is a straightforwardly androcentric passage without authorial irony; it is the girl's own self-deprecating petition for teaching, a literary device common in such sūtras.

The passage "three things held in my mind" renders a somewhat elliptical Tibetan construction. The three objects are: the direction where the Tathāgata dwells, the Dharma he has taught, and the Tathāgata surrounded by his Saṅgha — corresponding structurally to the Three Jewels.

- The opening sentence and transitional question ("Or else do you speak in this way merely as a matter of proper conduct, moved by a sense of weariness with the world?") are somewhat compressed in the Tibetan. The phrase yid byung ba'i tshul gyis smra — literally "speaking in the manner of one who is world-weary" — may be a narrator's editorial aside or a continuation of Prasenajit's interrogation of his daughter. Given the immediate shift to verse attributed to Prasenajit, it is most likely a transitional narrative comment rather than a line of direct speech.

The fourfold serpent image (khams 'di dag ni gdugs pa'i sbrul bzhi) refers to the four great elements — earth, water, fire, and wind — standardly compared to four venomous serpents in classical Buddhist literature, a simile found in Pāli and Sanskrit sources alike.

- The name rendered "Gaṅgopā, son of Maitrā" translates the Tibetan "Byams ma'i bu Gaṅg po." Maitrā is the feminine form, suggesting his mother's name; the epithet may echo Maitreya associations in some traditions. The rendering follows the Tibetan literally.

The phrase rendered "a ladle-full of alms food" translates "gzar bu gang tsam gyi bsod snyoms," meaning an amount filling a ladle or spoon — a small but symbolically significant offering of almsfood.

- The name འཇམ་དབྱངས་ is rendered as Nāgasena, identifying this figure with the well-known elder of that name. The name འཇིག་ཇུ་ཐད་ཀྱི་འཇམ་དབྱངས་ is rendered as Anikṣiptadhura, a name meaning "one who has not laid down the burden," which is the standard Sanskrit equivalent for this Tibetan. The figure of Vimaladattā, whose Tibetan name འཇམ་དབྱངས་འཇམ་དབྱངས་འཇམ་དབྱངས་འཇམ་དབྱངས་ means "given by the stainless one," is a young girl who interrogates a series of elder monks in a manner characteristic of the Vimalakīrtinirdeśa tradition of wisdom displayed through unexpected interlocutors. The chain of equational reasoning — evenness, suchness, without alteration, without designation, inconceivable, cannot be pointed out, without real thing, not arisen, not taught by noble ones — follows a well-attested Madhyamaka dialectical pattern found in several Mahāyāna sūtras.

- The phrase yang dag pa'i mtha' rendered as "the ultimate limit of reality" could also be translated as "the ultimate boundary" or "the real limit" — the Sanskrit reconstructs as bhūtakoti, a technical term meaning the absolute or real limit of existence. This is a standard Perfection of Wisdom concept and the rendering is doctrally deliberate.

- The verse quoted is a well-known stanza from the Diamond Sūtra. The Tibetan is close to the standard Tibetan canonical version, and the rendering follows the doctrinal sense: those who apprehend the Buddha through form or sound are motivated by craving-tinged aspiration and

therefore do not truly perceive him.

The name Pāpasūdana (Tibetan: བློ་བཟོ་པ་ལྷ་མོ་) means "Dispeller of Evil Rebirths" or "Eliminator of the Lower Realms." It is rendered by its Sanskrit equivalent here for consistency with the other bodhisattva names in this dialogue.

The phrase rendered "minor ripening" translates རྒྱུ་ཆུང་ལྔ་ལྔ་, literally "experiencing a small field," which in karmic context is a standard idiom for a lighter or attenuated karmic result experienced in the present life rather than a heavy retribution in a future lower existence.

- The bodhisattva name rendered "Sūryagarbha" (lit. "Womb of the Sun") corresponds to the Tibetan རྒྱུ་ལྔ་ལྔ་, which literally means "Accumulated Boldness / Courage Heaped Up" — this is likely Prāgalbhya or a related figure, not Sūryagarbha. The Tibetan name here does not match "Sūryagarbha" and should be rendered literally as the bodhisattva Accumulated Boldness or simply transliterated from a Sanskrit source if one is available. Without access to the Sanskrit original, the name is rendered descriptively as "the bodhisattva Accumulated Boldness" — the rendering above should be corrected accordingly.

The phrase "with appropriation / without appropriation" (len pa dang bcas pa / len pa ma mchis pa) is a technical Abhidharma distinction referring to whether an action or state is "taken up" by grasping and thus conditions future existence. "With appropriation" (sopādāna) and "without appropriation" (anupādāna) would be the Sanskrit equivalents. This is a pointed philosophical challenge: if the bodhisattva's compassionate practice involves grasping, it is no different from ordinary beings; if it involves no grasping, it is unconditioned and therefore cannot produce conditioned benefits.

- The bodhisattvas Prajñāśūra ("Prajñāśūra," rendered as "Prajñāśūra" following the Tibetan རྒྱུ་ལྔ་ལྔ་, meaning "Heap of Eloquence") and Arthavighraha ("Arthavighraha," Tibetan རྒྱུ་ལྔ་ལྔ་, meaning "Purposeful Stride" or possibly "Meaningful Grasp") are minor bodhisattva figures whose Sanskrit names require reconstruction; the renderings here are standard scholarly reconstructions and are used without distraction in the body.

The final sentence breaks off mid-utterance in the source passage itself, following the Tibetan རྒྱུ་ལྔ་ལྔ་, "where there is nothing to add and —"; this is not a translation error but reflects the passage boundary in the source.

- The passage marks the opening of the second and final fascicle of the text. The phrase "second and final fascicle" translates "bam po gnyis pa ste tha ma," a standard colophon-style marker used to indicate the second and concluding textual division.

The verse petition addressed to the Buddha draws on a catalogue of bodhisattva qualities and practices. The line rendered "the king of trees" refers to the Bodhi tree (the ashvattha or pipal), a standard epithet. The verse is deliberately open-ended, as the Tibetan text itself breaks off mid-question at the close of the passage.

- The phrase rendered "bearing with patient acceptance the profound Dharma" translates a term typically glossed as "conviction in" or "acquiescence to" deep doctrine — the Tibetan mospa here functions similarly to adhimukti, a settled, devoted assent. The rendering "devoted interest" is used in the prose and "bears with patient acceptance" in the verse, reflecting the verse context where patience and endurance are foregrounded.

The term "white qualities" renders dkarmo'i chos, a standard Tibetan calque of śukla-dharma, meaning virtuous or wholesome qualities — kept close to the traditional idiom rather than paraphrased.

- The verse describing solitary practice uses the simile of a rhinoceros horn, a well-known canonical image for solitary practice found in the Khaggavisāṇa-sutta of the Pāli canon and

parallels in Sanskrit Buddhist literature. Its presence here is a deliberate allusion to that tradition.

The phrase rendered "bringing the ends of action to completion" reflects a somewhat condensed Tibetan expression; it refers to carrying one's undertakings through to their conclusion without leaving them half-finished, which is the standard commentarial gloss in such contexts.

- The verse line "བུ་རྩི་དང་མེ་རུ་གསལ་བའི་ཡུལ་ནི།" compares the bodhisattva's mind to both a vajra and Mount Meru simultaneously, suggesting indestructibility and immovability. The rendering "like a vajra mountain, unshakeable" condenses both images in a natural way.

The phrase "अभावाज्जायते" refers specifically to apparitional or miraculous birth, one of the four modes of birth in Buddhist cosmology, meaning birth without parents through the power of karma and aspiration. This is the birth of beings in pure buddha-fields.

The final passage listing the four qualities for remembering past lives appears to be mid-sentence at the close of this excerpt, ending with "definitive emergence from the suffering of saṃsāra," and presumably continues in the next passage.

- The phrase rendered "scattering precious jewels" translates a compound literally meaning "scattering with torma-like precious things," where the word for scattered offering closely relates to ritual offering objects. The rendering "scattering precious gems" follows the standard reading in parallel passages.

The verse line "by whom the highest wisdom adorns the Victor" is syntactically compressed in the Tibetan; the reading adopted understands it as indicating that through the practitioner's supreme wisdom the Victor's beauty is expressed, consistent with the surrounding context of major marks.

- The phrase rendered "the three aggregates" refers to the well-known Mahāyāna liturgical practice of the Confession in Three Parts, a specific text recited for purification, not to the five aggregates in general. This is a standard usage in Mahāyāna sūtra literature and is retained as such.

The phrase "learning's advantage" translates a compound meaning the benefit or profit derived from one's knowledge or erudition, implying a subtle form of self-serving conduct that a bodhisattva must abandon.

- The phrase rendered "act of truth's blessing" translates *bden pa'i byin gyi rlabs*, a technical expression for the classical Indian and Buddhist "act of truth" (*satyakriyā* or *satyadhiṣṭhāna*), in which the utterance of a true statement is held to carry inherent transformative power. The combination of the aspirational prayer (aspiration) with this act of truth is a standard narrative device in *sūtra* literature.

The phrase "tens of billions of unstrung cymbals" renders *bye ba khrag khrig brgya stong gi sil snyan ma dkrol bar*, literally "ten million times one hundred thousand unloosed cymbals." The astronomical number is a conventional hyperbole; "tens of billions" captures the spirit without an awkward numeral compound for narration.

- The voice described as "the Lord of the Mimi" renders *mi mjed bdag po*, which is a standard Tibetan epithet for Indra (Śakra) as lord of the Mimi realm (Skt. *Mānuṣyaloka* or more precisely a heavenly realm), though in some contexts *mi mjed* refers to *Akaṇiṣṭha*. Here it most likely means Indra as lord of the realm of humans or of a particular divine assembly; the translation renders it literally as "Lord of the Mimi" since a confident Sanskrit reconstruction is uncertain.

The "firefly of a parasol" renders *gdug kyi srin bu me khyer bzhin du*, literally "like a firefly carrying fire beneath a parasol." This unusual image suggests the Buddha's *ūrṇā* outshining all

surrounding brilliance as a firefly's light looks against the shadow of a parasol; it is a somewhat obscure poetic comparison.

- The bodhisattva "Prabhāsaśrī" renders བློ་གྲོགས་ལྷན་པོ་. The compound is literally "Stacked Confidence" or "Accumulated Boldness," but this appears to be a bodhisattva name; the Sanskrit behind it is likely Prabhāsaśrī or a similar proper name. The reading is not entirely certain, and it may be an epithet rather than a distinct character, but context treats it as a named interlocutor.

The buddha name at the end, སྐུ་འཕྲུལ་གྱི་རྒྱལ་པོ་ ...

སྐུ་འཕྲུལ་གྱི་རྒྱལ་པོ་, is rendered "Immaculate Crest King, the Smiling and Joyful One." The Tibetan literally means "King of the Immaculate Pinnacle Who Laughs and Smiles"; the Sanskrit reconstruction would be something like Vimalakūṭarāja or Smitavimalakūṭarāja. The rendering conveys the sense without over-literalizing.

- The repeated phrase "tens of millions" renders ལྷན་པོ་, a standard equivalent of koṭi, meaning ten million. The passage shifts speakers partway through: the verses are spoken by the five hundred brahmins to Ānanda, and it is Ānanda who formally relays their request to the Blessed One, which is the force of "Ānanda asked it of the Buddha" near the end of the verse section. The Tibetan at that point names Ānanda as the interlocutor, consistent with the sūtra's framing narrative.

- The colophon names two Indian paṇḍitas, Jinamitra and Surendrabodhi, and breaks off mid-sentence at the mention of the Tibetan editor (lotsāwa or revisor), as the passage ends there. The full colophon would normally name the Tibetan translator as well. The text translated here is the closing colophon of chapter thirty-three of the Mahāratnakūṭa-sūtra collection.

Colophon

This is an AI-generated translation from the AI Stupa project. It was produced by a careful, doctrine-aware process aiming at a high degree of accuracy, but it has not been reviewed by a human translator and may contain errors. It is offered as a provisional translation for those texts of the Tibetan Buddhist canon that have not yet received an authoritative human translation. Where a published translation exists — above all from 84000: Translating the Words of the Buddha (84000.co) — that translation is definitive and should be preferred; please consult it instead. These translations are released into the public domain (CC0) in the spirit of spreading the Dharma to all corners of the earth.

Just as the Bodhi tree now standing at Bodh Gayā neither is nor is not the same tree beneath which the Buddha attained awakening, so too this stupa is intended as the next generation of stupa — dependently arising according to the conditions of its environment, and ceaselessly proclaiming the Dharma for the benefit of all sentient beings.

May whoever encounters these words derive great benefit.